

eight years since then, I've not gone past that."

Sarvesh knows too.

"I jumped 2.26m for the first time in 2019. It's taken seven years to go from there to beyond 2.30," he told *Sportstar* after the competition.

The challenge of improvement is made harder by the nature of the event.

"Unfortunately, here you can't make a jump and then see how far you have gone. You could have a 2.30m-plus jump, but it might have come when the bar was set at 2.28m.

"And when you do set the bar at 2.31m [like Sarvesh did], you are forced to look at it and feel the magnitude of all the things you need to overcome before actually overcoming it. That's why I think these events are really tough mentally," he says.

Makeshift pit

For Sarvesh, 31, the long line of things he had to overcome did not begin on this historic evening.

Growing up in Devargaon village in Nashik district, with a population of less than 3,000, Sarvesh's father wanted him to become an engineer. However, he was adamant about pursuing a career in the high jump.

With no proper facility to train in the village, Sarvesh's first coach used corn husk, agricultural waste, old clothes and cotton to prepare a makeshift pit that the youngster would leap into.

Sarvesh, whose national career began 12 years ago, would go on to accomplish far more than anyone in Devargaon could have imagined.

He emerged from Tejaswin's shadow to become national champion in his own right. He competed at the 2024 Olympics. Then, at the 2025 World Championships in Tokyo, he did something few Indian athletes had managed — make the final and eventually finish sixth.

All of that was impressive, but Sarvesh — in the mould of a truly special athlete — was not done yet. He had his sights set on breaching the 2.30m barrier.

He had been chasing the mark for several years already, and there were enough naysayers who believed it could not be done. At 1.79m in height, Sarvesh is relatively short for a high jumper, the overwhelming majority of whom stand well over six feet tall.

He had come close on multiple occasions. After jumping 2.28m at the World Championships final last year, he repeated the mark at the Federation Cup in Ranchi last month.

He even attempted 2.30m in that competition but was unable to secure the clearance after twisting his right ankle during an earlier attempt.

On the night he breached 2.30m, both Sarvesh and his coach Jithin Thomas — himself a former Asian Championships silver medallist in the high jump — sensed that something special was about to happen. Jithin noticed it first.

"For two weeks before the competition, Sarvesh had become very quiet," he says.

On the morning of the competition, Jithin told Sarvesh that this was his day.

"Before the competition, my coach told me no Indian had ever done 2.30. He said if you do it, you will be the first. As long as there is high jump in India, your name will be there as the one who got to 2.30 first," Sarvesh recalls.

Sarvesh started with a clean jump at 2.12m, cleared 2.19m after one miss, and then made successful clearances at 2.22m, 2.25m and 2.27m, all first attempts.

He had already won the competition with 2.27m but, rather than settle for the national record (2.30m), he raised the bar to 2.31m.

Psychological switch

"The reason behind this was purely psychological. I've attempted 2.30m a few times before and never got it. For many months, I had senior officials constantly ask me when I was going to get to 2.30. Maybe there was something about the number. So I decided to go for 2.31m," he says.

Perhaps a bit over-eager, he

clattered the bar in his first two attempts. Ahead of his final attempt, though, he composed himself. It was all up to him.

"Normally the coach constantly tells me, '*Ho jayega, ho jayega*' (It will happen; it will happen). But this time he was silent," Sarvesh says.

On that final attempt, everything went perfectly. While the result was only confirmed when his heels finally crossed the bar, Tejaswin, watching from the USA where he is preparing for the decathlon, says he knew the outcome three paces before Sarvesh took off.

"You could tell that the rhythm of the run was spot on. For me, he made 2.31m three steps before he actually made it because that's when I could tell he had done all the right things for the curve to throw him over the bar," Shankar says.

It might have been the first, but Tejaswin believes it will not be the last time Sarvesh clears 2.30m.

"Honestly, there's nothing technically that changes between a 2.28m jump and a 2.30m-plus jump. It's just a mental block and now that's been overcome," he says.

Indeed, after acknowledging the embraces of his compatriots and the cheers from the fans in the stands, Sarvesh set the bar at 2.35m. He made two more attempts and, although he missed both, it was clear he had found a new boundary to chase.

"When you jump over 2.30m, you know you will always be in contention for a medal at most international competitions. But when you jump 2.35m, you are in the fight for a medal at the World Championships and Olympics," he says. The gold medal winning jump at the 2024 Olympics and 2025 Worlds was 2.36m.

The journey from this point will only get harder, but Sarvesh seems ready for it.

"I'm improving a lot. The height is not an easy one but if your preparation is good, then nothing is impossible. I've never attempted 2.35m before but *ho jayega*. I'll try to get it at the Commonwealth or Asian Games," he says.